

355 Make a compost heap

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Left to itself, nature is a top recycler, but if you want to give nature a hand, build a compost heap. You'll not only reduce the amount of garbage going into landfills, but your garden will also get some great free compost, too!

What you need

- An old wooden crate
- Brown-layer items—twigs, paper, dry stems, hair
- Green-layer items—grass clippings, fruit and vegetable peels

1 Choose a site for your compost container. The best is on bare soil in a sunny place. Ask an adult to help you build a simple box out of scrap wood if you don't already have a box or crate that's large enough.

2 Start your heap by adding dry "brown" layers—shredded newspapers and dry straw are ideal. Add a layer of "green" items on top. Alternate the layers so you have half green and half brown.

3 Don't add cooked food, fish, dairy, or meat products—they will attract mice. Turn your heap with pitchfork every few weeks. After a year, your compost should be ready to use.

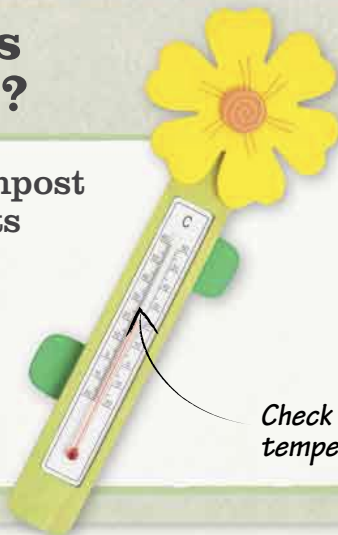


Keep a 50/50 mix of "green" to "brown" items

356 How hot is your heap?

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You can check that your compost heap is working by taking its temperature. Insert a long thermometer into the center of the heap. If it reads 104–122°F (40–50°C), then your heap is breaking down at the correct rate.



Check the temperature